

Hey, friends, it's Eric Malzone, and we are back for the next audio lecture installment on building credibility as a podcaster in the fitness, health, and wellness space. Credibility-- it's a big deal, especially for what we do in our industries. Overall, it's really not that complicated to build your credibility. It can take some time, but it can also be lost in a second. So be diligent.

And if I could give some overall thoughts on it, it goes like this-- be authentic. Be transparent. Be professional. Be honest. And if you can, entertaining and creativity goes a long way. So that's what I would say, and we're going to break this down.

So let's start about showcasing your personal expertise. Everyone has their own journey. All of us have come to this industry through different angle, for different reasons, unique paths that I think really are important, that you tell your story well and you tell it often. And you can mention your certifications, your degrees, your relevant experience. Definitely, more than anything, be factual, not braggadocious. That's just my personal opinion and taste, but that always turns me off.

So for example, I'll tell you my story. I got introduced to sports at the age of five. I got in competitive swimming mainly because I was a chubby, little asthmatic kid, and it was the best sport for me. And I actually took a liking to it. I was fairly good at it. And that allowed me to find water polo around the age of 12, maybe 13, and I really like that.

And I did it for a long time. I did it for about 20 years through college and club teams and had the opportunity to coach the sport at different levels as well. And I just fell in love with the whole thing about athletics and sports performance and teams and camaraderie and fitness and lifting weights and all of that. I just loved it.

And when I got the opportunity to open a CrossFit gym right around 2008, a college teammate of mine, Traver Boehm, sent me a text message and said, hey, man, you want to open a gym? About 10 minutes later, I said, yeah, let's do it. So that's about as complicated as the story began.

And we opened CrossFit Pacific Coast, and that was open for about nine years, opened a secondary gym about six years into it. That was a slightly different methodology but kind of CrossFit-ey. But I got all the education. I got eight or nine CrossFit certifications, specialty certs, level 2, level 3, did OPEX education. James Fitzgerald, the very first CrossFit Games champion in 2007, was my coach and mentor for a period of years and offered a lot of different education that I took, gobbled it up, got some really pointed nutrition certifications.

And all that being said, the best education I got was working with clients, so having the opportunity to work with thousands and thousands of clients that came through our door from post-bariatric surgery patients to high-level athletes at the college level to everyday Joes and Janes, it was an amazing experience. And when I finally decided to sell the gyms and move on, I started my podcast, *Future of Fitness*, and I started Fitness Sports Radio.

I do work for Athletech News. I do a bunch of different podcasting. I've had the opportunity to interview probably well over 800 people within the fitness, health, and wellness industry. And I tell you all this because it's allowed me the opportunity to experience untold mistakes and learning lessons along the way.

I have screwed up more than anybody, and that's how I learn, I guess, the painful way. But hopefully, some of the stuff I've learned will seep through into this course and allow you to move forward on your path faster and better than if you had chosen to do it yourself. And that's why I said yes to doing this course, ultimately. So moving on, tell your story. Tell it often. Tell it authentically, and people will resonate with it. And I think that's really probably the most critical piece of building your credibility.

Social proof-- so it's always great. We in this profession that having social proof, having success stories and testimonials is really important, and don't be scared to share them. Even better, having the person providing the testimonial on the show doesn't hurt either. That provides a really nice texture to what you're doing.

For the podcast itself, reviews and testimonials as well-- always encouraging your listeners to review and ask for testimonials. I've sat at numerous dinner tables and grabbed someone's phone, subscribed to my podcast, and then asked them to listen to it and please review it, shameless, absolutely shameless. I admit it. But hey, that's what it takes for getting started.

But when I was really accumulating testimonials and reviews, I found it useful to read the reviews during an episode. So if Sue from Oregon left me a nice review, I would read it and credit Sue and say, thank you for doing it, really appreciate it. And everybody out there, if you leave a nice review, I will read it on a podcast, so a nice way to build some momentum and let people know that it doesn't take a lot of time, but it goes a long way, and it's super appreciated.

Collaborations-- so one of the best way to build credibility is to collaborate with other people, and I'm talking about other reputable people within the industry, influencers, podcasters. Do cross promotions. Do panels. Do podcast swaps. It's probably the fastest way to gain credibility within this space specifically.

Ultimately, what your guests are looking for is high-quality content. So when you think about restaurants that you like to go to, probably majority of them you go to because-- not that it's the best food in the world. But it's good food, and it's consistently good food. So that's why people-- whether it's conscious or subconscious, people love consistent, solid podcast.

That's why they tune in. They may not love every episode, but they know over time that you're continually pumping out a certain amount of quality ones that resonate with them. So it's really important when you're doing high-quality content to be consistent. Do your research. Do your preparation for each episode. Check the facts.

If you get something wrong, that's OK too. Just make sure that you go back, you correct it, and I would either go back to the episode that you did, cut it out, put in an insertion and say, hey, I screwed up here, I stand corrected-- and overall, I feel like when you admit-- I don't know if it's just me, but I find that telling people, hey, I've changed my mind, here's why, I feel like that builds a certain amount of humanity behind you as a podcast host where you're not the one sitting at the top of the mountain saying, I know it all.

Be like, hey, I'm learning just like you. Maybe I'm one or two chapters ahead in the book. But I'm certainly making mistakes, and here's one that I made. I think that's a really powerful way to build trust.

The other way-- if you do have a guest format, man, it's an incredibly powerful way to build credibility, getting well-known guests in the industry. I remember my first 10 episodes I was just interviewing friends and people I know and people I would see as all my level colleagues. And then I decided to reach out to Dan John. It took me a while. I was nervous.

Dan John, if you don't know him, is a very famous strength coach and author, and I've read all his books. And I was just very influenced and looked up to him. And I don't know why I held back from reaching out to him sooner because as soon as I emailed him, he emailed me back within 10 minutes, said, sure, I'll do it, and sent me his cell phone number, said, call me tomorrow, and we'll book a time.

I was floored, absolutely floored, and that was the lesson-- I'm like, you know what? I might as well just punch up because a lot of times it doesn't hurt to ask, and more often times than not, you make it a yes. And you can start to build your credibility that way. And it doesn't necessarily have to be your personal knowledge, but you can kind of ride on the back of giants.

So I really encourage you, if you do have a guest format, to punch up. Make sure, though, that you're validating their opinions or that you are stating disclaimers that just because something is said on the podcast by a guest it's not necessarily an opinion of you. You can always go back and fact-check it afterwards as well.

Building trust-- we talked about consistency. I think that's the biggest thing. I really do. I can't stress enough the importance of being consistent with a publishing schedule, the type of content that you provide, and who you're serving. If you're switching up like, well, today I'm going to serve gym owners, but tomorrow I'm going to serve people interested in a keto diet, those are two different audiences, but you have to make sure you're serving the same audience with the same mission with the same values consistently over time.

Engagement-- there's a lot of different ways to engage your audience, and I think this is probably the most fulfilling part is when you actually get to engage because a lot of times you're just recording like I am right now, and you're sending it off into the world. You see that some people are listening as you're tracking numbers, but you don't really have that connection with the people themselves.

And when you do, it really fills your sails, man. It really does. So finding ways to do that, whether that be going to live events, through your social media channels, email blasts, whatever it may be, find creative ways to actually engage with your audience in a two-way flow, and you'll be building some credibility because people love to have that relationship with you too.

Continuous learning and adaptation-- so if there's one industry that suffers more from misinformation, differing opinions, or just having consumers that are generally baffled, it's our industry. And if you can fill that space as a trusted source of honest and unbiased information, you will build credibility quite quickly.

So stay up to date. Know what the trends are doing. Know where people's pain points are. Where are they confused? Where are they lost? Who's confusing them now? And being that trusted source, being that reliable source will be really critical in building your credibility as a podcaster.

Lastly, you're going to get some feedback, especially if you start a YouTube channel. Those people seem to love to throw feedback your way. It can be rough at times, and we're going to talk about in later chapters. But try to have a nice filter for that. Work through the stuff that you can control, things that you think can improve.

Be open to feedback, and always respect people as well. They may not be respectful to you all the time, but you can always be respectful, answer with a simple thank you, appreciate your time in putting this post up or this comment or reaching it out. And that's probably the best way to handle it, I could say.

Finally, just to recap, this isn't rocket science, building your credibility. There could be a lot of science involved in it overall, but it takes time. It's really easy to lose. You got to protect your reputation. And just focus on being authentic, transparent, professional, honest, and sprinkle in a healthy dose of creativity and showmanship, and you'll do great. Thanks for listening.